OXFORD CIRCUIT

BERKSHIRE

COUNTY GAOL AT READING

The following verses are written over the debtors' grate to the street:

> Oh ye whose hours exempt from sorrow flow,
> Behold the seat of pain and want and woe:
> Think, while your hands th' entreated alms extend,
> That what to us ye give, to God ye lend.

I observed that the women were not only chained together by their hands, but had heavy irons also on their legs, as they were conducted to the sessions house.

When felons come to this prison, they are washed, and clothes provided by the county are put on. The men have a Russia-drab coat and breeches, a flannel waistcoat, two check shirts, and two pairs of yarn hose: the women, a linsey woolsey gown and petticoat, a flannel petticoat, two dowlas shifts, two pairs of yarn hose. Their own clothes are ticketed and hung up till the quarter sessions or assizes; when they put them on again to appear in on trial. Afterwards the county-clothes are washed, mended, and purified in an oven, for the use of future criminals. The clothing aforesaid for twenty men and five women cost only £26 6s. 8d. A gentleman sent to this gaol for the prisoners thirty-six rugs or coverlets which are now worn out.

COUNTY BRIDEWELLS

READING. This is also the town bridewell. It was formerly a church, and is a spacious room, with four dark suffocating huts on one side for night-rooms, one for men sixteen feet by ten and a half and six and a half high; aperture in the door eight inches by five; straw worn to dust, not changed for four months: one for women fifteen feet eight inches by ten feet

nine inches; aperture in the door seven inches by five; the two other rooms less. The county pays rent to the corporation. It is dirty, and out of repair. Men and women are together in the daytime. No court: no water: allowance to felons, threepence a day; and to petty offenders, two pint loaves each, every Sunday, and one every week-day. Keeper's salary £18 from the county; £2 from the town: fees, 4s. 4d., no table; licence for beer: half the profit of the prisoners' work: £2 a year to find them straw. Clauses against spirituous liquors hung up: and there were on a board, some orders to be observed, approved by J. P. Andrews and Ferd. Collins, justices, 28 April, 1778.

1776, 1 Jan. prisoners 6. 1779, 21 April, prisoners 7.
1776, 1 Nov. „ 6. 1782, 5 March, „ 13.

"A new prison, containing six close (called refractory) cells, nine feet and a half by seven and a half; eight solitary cells, ten feet by seven feet nine inches, with courts about the same size; and six wards for prisoners, who are permitted to be together. The rooms are furnished with bedsteads and straw mattresses, but no coverlets. The sewers make most of the rooms and courts offensive. Here is a chapel, where the worthy chaplain officiates twice a week. Allowance, a threepenny loaf daily (weight 2 lb. 3 oz.) and meat on Sundays. No employment. Keeper's salary £50. No fees. The names of the prisoners, and terms of confinement, are written on the doors of their cells. I observed some were for one year: a severe confinement, to be so long in solitude, unemployed, in nauseous cells, and without fire in winter.[1]

1788, 12 July, prisoners 17."

[From *An Account of Lazarettos*, pp. 169, 192.]

[1] "I wish all prisoners to have separate rooms; for hours of thoughtfulness and reflection are necessary. The gentlemen of this county, by their building this house of correction, and in various other instances, have shown themselves so attentive, and zealous in whatever may contribute to the real interests of their fellow-creatures, that I am glad to take this occasion of making some remarks on solitary confinement. The intention of this, I mean by day as well as by night, is either to reclaim the most atrocious and daring criminals; to punish the refractory for crimes committed in prison; or to make a strong impression, in a short time, upon thoughtless and irregular young persons, as faulty apprentices, and the like. It should therefore be considered by those who are ready to commit, for a long term, petty offenders to absolute solitude, that such a state is more than human nature can bear, without the hazard of distraction or despair; that it is repugnant to the Act which orders all persons in houses of correction to work; and that for want of some employment in the day (as in several houses of correction) health is injured, and a